GCSE

English Language

Paper 1 Explorations in creative reading and writing

Mark scheme

Mark schemes are prepared by the Lead Assessment Writer and considered, together with the relevant questions, by a panel of subject teachers. This mark scheme includes any amendments made at the standardisation events which all associates participate in and is the scheme which was used by them in this examination. The standardisation process ensures that the mark scheme covers the students' responses to questions and that every associate understands and applies it in the same correct way. As preparation for standardisation each associate analyses a number of students' scripts. Alternative answers not already covered by the mark scheme are discussed and legislated for. If, after the standardisation process, associates encounter unusual answers which have not been raised they are required to refer these to a Senior Examiner.

It must be stressed that a mark scheme is a working document, in many cases further developed and expanded on the basis of students' reactions to a particular paper. Assumptions about future mark schemes on the basis of one year's document should be avoided; whilst the guiding principles of assessment remain constant, details will change, depending on the content of a particular examination paper.

Further copies of this mark scheme are available from aqa.org.uk

Introduction

The information provided for each question is intended to be a guide to the kind of answers anticipated and is neither exhaustive nor prescriptive. **All appropriate responses should be given credit.**

Level of response marking instructions

Level of response mark schemes for GCSE English Language are broken down into four levels (where appropriate). In the first column each level is identified with one or two key words that represent the differences in the skills then described. These key words show the progression from Level 1 to 4 and are:

Level 4	Perceptive, detailed
Level 3	Clear, relevant
Level 2	Some, attempts
Level 1	Simple, limited.

This is followed in the second column by a description of the different qualities required in the student's answer for that level. These are called the skills descriptors. In order to reach a given level, a student must fulfil one or more of the skills descriptors for that level.

The third column of the mark scheme is the Indicative Standard. This is an important feature of the mark scheme for GCSE English Language. It provides exemplification of the skills descriptors at each level and offers a small number of different comments at the required standard to give an indication of the quality of response that is typical for that level. It shows the progression from Level 1 to 4.

The Indicative Standard is not intended to be a model answer nor a complete response, and it does not exemplify required content. Students may reach a given level by making **one or more** comments of the quality demonstrated by the Indicative Standard and do not have to meet all the skill descriptors at that level.

The standardising scripts will further exemplify each of the levels. You must refer to the standardising material **throughout your marking**.

Step 1 Annotate the response

When marking a response you should first read through the student's answer and annotate each section using the comments from the statement bank to show the qualities that are being demonstrated, as instructed during standardising. You can then award a level and a mark.

Step 2 Determine a level

Start at the lowest level of the mark scheme and use it as a ladder to see whether the answer meets the descriptors for that level. The descriptors for the level indicate the different qualities that might be seen in the student's answer for that level. If it meets the lowest level then go to the next one and decide if it meets this level, and so on, until you have a match between the level descriptor and the answer. With practice and familiarity you will find that for better answers you will be able to quickly skip through the lower levels of the mark scheme.

The Indicative Standard column in the mark scheme will help you determine the correct level. Remember, students may reach a given level by making **one or more** comments of the quality demonstrated by the Indicative Standard and do **not** have to meet all the skill descriptors at that level. It is not the number of references, but the quality of the comments that will determine the level. The annotation you added to the script at Step 1 will help you determine the correct level.

Step 3 Determine a mark

Once you have assigned a level you need to decide on the mark. This requires you to fine tune within the level to see how well each of the skills descriptors for that level has been met. A student only has to meet a skills descriptor at a given level **once** to be awarded that level. Since responses rarely match a level in all respects, you need to balance out the range of skills achieved and allow strong performance in some aspects to compensate for other skills that may be only partially fulfilled. Again, the annotation added at Step 1 will help you determine the mark.

Reference to the standardising scripts throughout the marking period is essential. This will help you apply the level descriptors accurately and consistently. There will usually be an answer in the standardising materials which will correspond with each level of the mark scheme. This answer will have been awarded a mark by the Lead Examiner. You can compare the student's answer with the example to determine if it is the same standard, better or worse than the example. You can then use this to allocate a mark for the answer based on the Lead Examiner's mark on the example.

You may well need to read back through the answer as you apply the mark scheme to clarify points and assure yourself that the level and the mark are appropriate.

An answer which contains nothing of relevance to the question must be awarded no marks.

Advice

In fairness to students, all examiners must use the same marking methods. The following advice may seem obvious, but all examiners must follow it closely.

1. Refer constantly to the mark scheme and standardising scripts throughout the marking period.

2. Always credit accurate, relevant and appropriate responses that are not necessarily covered by the mark scheme or the standardising scripts.

3. Use the full range of marks. Do not hesitate to give full marks if the response merits it.

4. Remember the key to accurate and fair marking is consistency.

5. If you have any doubt about how to allocate marks to a response, consult your Team Leader.

SECTION A: READING – Assessment Objectives

AO1	• Identify and interpret explicit and implicit information and ideas. • Select and synthesise evidence from different texts.
AO2	• Explain, comment on and analyse how writers use language and structure to achieve effects and influence readers, using relevant subject terminology to support their views.
AO3	• Compare writers' ideas and perspectives, as well as how these are conveyed, across two or more texts.
AO4	• Evaluate texts critically and support this with appropriate textual references.

SECTION B: WRITING – Assessment Objectives

AO5	• Communicate clearly, effectively and imaginatively, selecting and adapting tone, style and register for different forms, purposes and audiences. • Organise information and ideas, using structural and grammatical features to support coherence and cohesion of texts.
AO6	• Candidates must use a range of vocabulary and sentence structures for clarity, purpose and effect, with accurate spelling and punctuation. (This requirement must constitute 20% of the marks for each specification as a whole).

Assessment Objective	Section A
AO1	✓
AO2	✓
AO3	**N/A**
AO4	✓
	Section B
AO5	✓
AO6	✓

0	1

Read again the first part of the source, from **lines 1 to 4**.

List **four** things about Mr Fisher from this part of the source.

[4 marks]

Give 1 mark for each point about Mr Fisher:

- responses must be true, and drawn only from lines 1 to 4 of the text
- responses must relate to **Mr Fisher**
- students may quote or paraphrase
- a paraphrased response covering more than one point should be credited for each point made – though paraphrased responses must demonstrate evidence of identification of information that is specific to the focus of the question as required by AO1
- responses that copy the whole section of the text from lines 1 to 4 verbatim should not be credited any marks as this does not provide any evidence of identification of information that is specific to the focus of the question as required by AO1.

Note: The indicative content must not be treated as exhaustive and reference must be made to the selected section of the text.

AO1	• Identify and interpret explicit and implicit information and ideas • Select and synthesise evidence from different texts
This assesses bullet point 1: identify and interpret explicit and implicit information and ideas	
Indicative content; students may include: • he lived alone • he lived in a terraced house • he lived in a small house • he lived in the centre of town • he didn't own a car • he did much of his weekend marking at school • he travelled home by bus • he took some books and papers home at the weekend to mark Also credit: • he is a teacher • marking in the form room • marking after school • he worked in school • he does his marking Or any other valid responses that you are able to verify by checking the source. Do not credit: • he did as much of his marking as he could • he did as much as he could in the form room • two or three stacks of books to take home • small terraced house (needs to reference living in the house) • did not drive • lonely (not the same as alone)	

0 2 Look in detail at this extract, from **lines 9 to 15** of the source:

(Extract in question paper)

How does the writer use language here to convey Mr Fisher's views on books and stories of the past?

You could include the writer's choice of:

- words and phrases
- language features and techniques
- sentence forms.

[8 marks]

AO2 Explain, comment on and analyse how writers use language and structure to achieve effects and influence readers, using relevant subject terminology to support their views		
This question assesses Language ie: Words/Phrases/Language Features/Language Techniques/Sentence Forms		
Level	**Skills Descriptors**	**Indicative Standard** This indicative standard provides an exemplification of the skills descriptors at each level. It is not a model answer, nor a complete response, nor does it seek to exemplify any particular content.
Level 4 Perceptive, detailed analysis 7-8 marks	Shows perceptive and detailed understanding of language: • Analyses the effects of the writer's choices of language • Selects a range of judicious textual detail • Makes sophisticated and accurate use of subject terminology	The writer uses the adjective 'golden' to suggest Mr Fisher has a nostalgic and romanticised view of books of the past. He thinks the world was full of stories which 'ran like gazelles and pounced like tigers', metaphorically conveying that not only were there many fast-paced stories but also that they ambushed the imagination so that the reader was totally immersed in the words on the page. The writer personifies the stories as 'illuminating minds and hearts' to imply that Mr Fisher believes every part of the reader was affected: not only did the stories reach the reader mentally but they captivated them emotionally, as if under a spell.
Level 3 Clear, relevant explanation 5-6 marks	Shows clear understanding of language: • Explains clearly the effects of the writer's choices of language • Selects a range of relevant textual detail • Makes clear and accurate use of subject terminology	The writer uses the adjective 'golden' to suggest Mr Fisher has a positive, glowing view of the books of the past. He says they were full of stories which 'ran like gazelles and pounced like tigers'. This metaphor conveys that the stories carried you along and were like fast moving animals, attacking the reader's imagination to make them gripped in what they were reading. The writer then uses the image 'illuminating minds and hearts', implying that Mr Fisher thinks that in the past, these stories lit up every part of the reader with enthusiasm.

Level 2 Some understanding and comment 3-4 marks	Shows some understanding of language: • Attempts to comment on the effect of language • Selects some appropriate textual detail • Makes some use of subject terminology, mainly appropriately	The writer uses the adjective 'golden' to describe books of the past, which makes it sound as if Mr Fisher thinks they were bright and enjoyable. The stories 'ran like gazelles and pounced like tigers', so they were really fast and some parts jumped out at you.
Level 1 Simple, limited comment 1-2 marks	Shows simple awareness of language: • Offers simple comment on the effect of language • Selects simple reference(s) or textual detail(s) • Makes simple use of subject terminology, not always appropriately	Mr Fisher likes the books of the past because he uses the word 'golden'. The writer says the stories 'pounced like tigers' so they must have made the reader jump.
Level 0 No marks	Nothing to reward	

Note: If a student writes only about language outside of the given lines, the response should be placed in either Level 1 or Level 2, according to the quality of what is written.

AO2 content may include the effect of ideas such as:

- use of metaphors, eg 'golden', to suggest a nostalgic, wistful view on books of the past
- animal imagery to convey how the stories attacked readers' imaginations
- use of personification, eg to demonstrate how the stories impacted both 'minds and hearts'

0 3 You now need to think about the **whole** of the source.

This text is from the beginning of a short story.

How has the writer structured the text to interest you as a reader?

You could write about:

- what the writer focuses your attention on at the beginning of the source
- how and why the writer changes this focus as the source develops
- any other structural features that interest you.

[8 marks]

AO2 Explain, comment on and analyse how writers use language and structure to achieve effects and influence readers, using relevant subject terminology to support their views		
This question assesses how the writer has structured a text. Structural features can be: at a whole text level eg. beginnings/endings/perspective shifts; at a paragraph level eg. topic change/aspects of cohesion; and at a sentence level when judged to contribute to whole structure.		
Level	**Skills Descriptors**	**Indicative Standard** This indicative standard provides an exemplification of the skills descriptors at each level. It is not a model answer, nor a complete response, nor does it seek to exemplify any particular content.
Level 4 Perceptive, detailed analysis 7-8 marks	Shows perceptive and detailed understanding of structural features: • Analyses the effects of the writer's choices of structural features • Selects a range of judicious examples • Makes sophisticated and accurate use of subject terminology	The source has a number of structural shifts in place, situation and especially time. It begins with some initial background information on Mr Fisher: we can visualise him in a domestic setting, his 'small terraced house', and also his workplace, a 'form room' at school, so a whole character is being established. The focus then narrows to his thoughts on teaching creative writing, and his gradual disenchantment over the years. This is shown structurally by alternating between the present and the past. First we learn that this school term has been 'disappointing' for him because he has struggled to engage his students' interest. Then in the middle section of the text, reference to 'the old days', followed by 'Mr Fisher remembered', heralds a flashback to a previous time. He describes a colourful past, filled with students whose 'imaginations soared', and when the focus then returns to the present time and everything is now 'in black and white', the reader understands how disillusioned Mr Fisher has become with teaching.

Level 3 Clear, relevant explanation 5-6 marks	Shows clear understanding of structural features: • Explains clearly the effects of the writer's choices of structural features • Selects a range of relevant examples • Makes clear and accurate use of subject terminology	After some background information about Mr Fisher at the beginning of the source, the focus shifts to his thoughts about teaching, and we learn how difficult he finds it to engage his students in creative writing. The middle section of the text starting 'Mr Fisher remembered a time' switches to the past, when 'whole classes were swept away' with enthusiasm for reading, before then coming back to the present time again. This flashback is important structurally because it gives the reader a comparison. At this point, we can see how Mr Fisher thinks the past was so much better, which therefore emphasises how bad teaching is for him now.
Level 2 Some understanding and comment 3-4 marks	Shows some understanding of structural features: • Attempts to comment on the effect of structural features • Selects some appropriate examples • Makes some use of subject terminology, mainly appropriately	Near the beginning, the writer focuses our attention on Mr Fisher's thoughts, and we learn how hard it is for him to interest his students in creative writing. Then it says 'Mr Fisher remembered a time' and the focus switches to the past when the boys liked stories, so it shows us it was different then.
Level 1 Simple, limited comment 1-2 marks	Shows simple awareness of structural features: • Offers simple comment on the effect of structure • Selects simple reference(s) or example(s) • Makes simple use of subject terminology, not always appropriately	At the beginning, the writer focuses our attention on Mr Fisher thinking about how the boys he teaches don't like books. Then he thinks back to the past and shows us it was different.
Level 0 No marks	Nothing to reward	

AO2 content may include the effect of ideas such as:

- use of structural shifts in place and situation at the beginning of the source to establish a rounded character and set in motion the narrative journey
- positioning of the key sentences, eg 'Mr Fisher remembered a time', to signpost a flashback
- juxtaposition of past and present to compare Mr Fisher's different experiences of teaching and emphasise his current disillusionment
- impact of Mr Fisher's internal thoughts on his external actions

0 4 Focus this part of your answer on the second part of the source, from **line 25 to the end**.

A student said, 'This part of the story, where Mr Fisher is marking homework, shows Tibbet's story is better than Mr Fisher expected, and his reaction is extreme.'

To what extent do you agree?

In your response, you could:

- consider your own impressions of what Mr Fisher expected Tibbet's homework to be like
- evaluate how the writer conveys Mr Fisher's reaction to what he discovers
- support your response with references to the text.

[20 marks]

AO4
Evaluate texts critically and support this with appropriate textual references

Level	**Skills Descriptors**	**Indicative Standard** This indicative standard provides an exemplification of the skills descriptors at each level. It is not a model answer, nor a complete response, nor does it seek to exemplify any particular content.
Level 4 Perceptive, detailed evaluation 16-20 marks	Shows perceptive and detailed evaluation: • Evaluates critically and in detail the effect(s) on the reader • Shows perceptive understanding of writer's methods • Selects a range of judicious textual detail • Develops a convincing and critical response to the focus of the statement	Mr Fisher is resigned to his students' lack of imagination and we learn that his expectations of Tibbet are low: despite 'a spark in him which deserved attention', Tibbet is not a 'brilliant scholar by any means' and 'had obviously done part of his homework on the bus'. Mr Fisher even 'took a deep breath' before marking Tibbet's book, the triple 'home; dinner; bed' emphasising to the reader the domestic distractions he would rather be doing. However, when he reads Tibbet's story, I think Mr Fisher is astounded because it is unique, totally fresh and 'something entirely original'. He experiences a moment of sudden realisation that is so profound that he will never look on life in the same way again. Everything he previously believed about stories has been shattered, and his reaction is not only emotional but physical. The writer conveys this by juxtaposing short, snappy sentences with long, complex ones to imitate the stages of astonishment Mr Fisher goes through. 'His breathing quickened, stopped, quickened again' suggests he is swiftly scanning through Tibbet's homework in disbelief, the rhythm mirroring his rapid heartbeat. This is followed by a lengthy sentence that includes the phrase 're-reading every word slowly and with meticulous care'. Here, the pace slows down to reflect Mr Fisher retracing his steps much more thoroughly, incredulous at his discovery.

Level 3 Clear, relevant evaluation 11-15 marks	Shows clear and relevant evaluation: • Evaluates clearly the effect(s) on the reader • Shows clear understanding of writer's methods • Selects a range of relevant textual references • Makes a clear and relevant response to the focus of the statement	Mr Fisher says Tibbet wasn't a 'brilliant scholar by any means', despite having a 'spark in him', so I don't think his expectations of Tibbet's homework were high. He even 'took a deep breath' before he started marking, which suggests he was dreading it and maybe thought he was wasting his time. When he reads the story, he discovers it's really good because it's original, and he is surprised and stunned. The writer conveys his extreme reaction by varying the sentence length as Mr Fisher reads the story. The short sharp sentence 'His breathing quickened, stopped, quickened again' implies that Mr Fisher is rushing through Tibbet's work as if in disbelief. This is followed by a long, complex sentence that includes 're-reading every word slowly and with meticulous care'. This slows the pace right down, suggesting Mr Fisher is now taking his time to see if what he has found can possibly be true.
Level 2 Some, evaluation 6-10 marks	Shows some attempts at evaluation: • Makes some evaluative comment(s) on effect(s) on the reader • Shows some understanding of writer's methods • Selects some appropriate textual reference(s) • Makes some response to the focus of the statement	Mr Fisher expected Tibbet's homework to be bad. He says 'not a brilliant scholar'. He also 'took a deep breath', which tells us he didn't really want to mark the book. I think Mr Fisher is surprised when he discovers Tibbet's story is good, and I agree he has an extreme reaction. He starts to sweat and 'his breathing quickened, stopped, quickened again'. This is a short sentence used for effect. You read it really quickly and it makes it seem like he can't breathe properly because he's so excited.
Level 1 Simple, limited comment 1-5 marks	Shows simple, limited evaluation: • Makes simple, limited evaluative comment(s) on effect(s) on reader • Shows limited understanding of writer's methods • Selects simple, limited textual reference(s) • Makes a simple, limited response to the focus of the statement	Mr Fisher thinks Tibbet's homework is going to be bad, but it turns out to be good. It says 'not a brilliant scholar by any means' so Mr Fisher didn't expect it to be any good. I agree Mr Fisher's reaction is extreme. This is shown in the short sentence 'His breathing quickened, stopped, quickened again'.
Level 0 No marks	Nothing to reward.	

Note: Reference to the writer's methods may be implicit without specific mention of the writer.

Similarly, the evaluative ‘I do/I don’t agree’ may be implicit.
In both these cases credit should be given according to the quality of what is written.

AO4 content may include the evaluation of ideas such as:

- Mr Fisher’s previous knowledge of Tibbet leading to low expectations of his work despite ‘a spark in him’
- Mr Fisher’s thoughts before beginning his marking
- Mr Fisher’s epiphany at discovering a totally original piece of creative writing
- the writer’s juxtaposition of various sentence lengths to reflect Mr Fisher’s astonishment
- whether or not Mr Fisher’s reaction is extreme.

0 5 A magazine has asked for contributions for their creative writing section.

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Either:

Write a description of an old person as suggested by this picture: (old man's face)

or

Write a story about a time when things turned out unexpectedly.

(24 marks for content and organisation and
16 marks for technical accuracy)
[40 marks]

AO5 Content and Organisation Communicate clearly, effectively and imaginatively, selecting and adapting tone, style and register for different forms, purposes and audiences. Organise information and ideas, using structural and grammatical features to support coherence and cohesion of texts.		
Level		**Skills descriptors**
Level 4 19-24 marks **Compelling, Convincing Communication**	Upper Level 4 22-24 marks	**Content** • Communication is convincing and compelling • Tone, style and register are assuredly matched to purpose and audience • Extensive and ambitious vocabulary with sustained crafting of linguistic devices **Organisation** • Varied and inventive use of structural features • Writing is compelling, incorporating a range of convincing and complex ideas • Fluently linked paragraphs with seamlessly integrated discourse markers
	Lower Level 4 19-21 marks	**Content** • Communication is convincing • Tone, style and register are convincingly matched to purpose and audience • Extensive vocabulary with conscious crafting of linguistic devices **Organisation** • Varied and effective structural features • Writing is highly engaging with a range of developed complex ideas • Consistently coherent use of paragraphs with integrated discourse markers

Level 3 13-18 marks **Consistent, Clear Communication**	Upper Level 3 16-18 marks	**Content** • Communication is consistently clear • Tone, style and register are clearly and consistently matched to purpose and audience • Increasingly sophisticated vocabulary and phrasing, chosen for effect with a range of successful linguistic devices **Organisation** • Effective use of structural features • Writing is engaging, using a range of, clear connected ideas • Coherent paragraphs with integrated discourse markers
	Lower Level 3 13-15 marks	**Content** • Communication is generally clear • Tone, style and register are generally matched to purpose and audience • Vocabulary clearly chosen for effect and appropriate use of linguistic devices **Organisation** • Usually effective use of structural features • Writing is engaging, with a range of connected ideas • Usually coherent paragraphs with range of discourse markers
Level 2 7-12 marks **Some successful Communication**	Upper Level 2 10-12 marks	**Content** • Communicates with some sustained success • Some sustained attempt to match tone, style and register to purpose and audience • Conscious use of vocabulary with some use of linguistic devices **Organisation** • Some use of structural features • Increasing variety of linked and relevant ideas • Some use of paragraphs and some use of discourse markers
	Lower Level 2 7-9 marks	**Content** • Communicates with some success • Attempts to match tone, style and register to purpose and audience • Begins to vary vocabulary with some use of linguistic devices **Organisation** • Attempts to use structural features • Some linked and relevant ideas • Attempt to write in paragraphs with some discourse markers, not always appropriate

<table>
<tr><td rowspan="2">Level 1

1-6 marks

Simple, Limited Communication</td><td>Upper Level 1

4-6 marks</td><td>Content
• Communicates simply
• Simple awareness of matching tone, style and register to purpose and audience
• Simple vocabulary; simple linguistic devices

Organisation
• Evidence of simple structural features
• One or two relevant ideas, simply linked
• Random paragraph structure</td></tr>
<tr><td>Lower Level 1

1-3 marks</td><td>Content
• Limited communication
• Occasional sense of matching tone, style and register to purpose and audience
• Simple vocabulary

Organisation
• Limited or no evidence of structural features
• One or two unlinked ideas
• No paragraphs</td></tr>
<tr><td>Level 0
No marks</td><td colspan="2">Students will not have offered any meaningful writing to assess.
Nothing to reward</td></tr>
</table>

AO6 Technical Accuracy Students must use a range of vocabulary and sentence structures for clarity, purpose and effect, with accurate spelling and punctuation. (This requirement must constitute 20% of the marks for each specification as a whole.)	
Level	**Skills descriptors**
Level 4 13-16 marks	• Sentence demarcation is consistently secure and consistently accurate • Wide range of punctuation is used with a high level of accuracy • Uses a full range of appropriate sentence forms for effect • Uses Standard English consistently and appropriately with secure control of complex grammatical structures • High level of accuracy in spelling, including ambitious vocabulary • Extensive and ambitious use of vocabulary
Level 3 9-12 marks	• Sentence demarcation is mostly secure and mostly accurate • Range of punctuation is used, mostly with success • Uses a variety of sentence forms for effect • Mostly uses Standard English appropriately with mostly controlled grammatical structures • Generally accurate spelling, including complex and irregular words • Increasingly sophisticated use of vocabulary
Level 2 5-8 marks	• Sentence demarcation is mostly secure and sometimes accurate • Some control of a range of punctuation • Attempts a variety of sentence forms • Some use of Standard English with some control of agreement • Some accurate spelling of more complex words • Varied use of vocabulary
Level 1 1-4 marks	• Occasional use of sentence demarcation • Some evidence of conscious punctuation • Simple range of sentence forms • Occasional use of Standard English with limited control of agreement • Accurate basic spelling • Simple use of vocabulary
Level 0 No marks	Students' spelling, punctuation etc. is sufficiently poor to prevent understanding or meaning.